

Formation Rules and the Language of Alignment

Seven on the line, two ends, one yard of depth: the handful of rules that decide who may catch a pass, and the vocabulary coaches use to put eleven players in the right spots.

A broadcast cuts to the line of scrimmage on first-and-10. The tight end jogs from the right side to the left. The wide receiver on the left, who had been standing a step back, inches forward until his toes almost touch the line, and glances at the official on the sideline, who nods. Meanwhile the referee switches on his microphone and announces to the whole stadium that number 70 “reports as eligible.” Why does a receiver care about one yard of depth? Why does a lineman have to *tell* anyone where he is standing? And why did the defense just change its front because one tight end changed sides?

This chapter answers all three. It covers the rules every formation has to obey and the vocabulary coaches use to talk about where players stand, and the two turn out to be bound together. Most of the names in this chapter exist *because* of the rules.

You’ll be able to...

- Check a formation for legality in a few seconds: count seven on the line, find the two ends, and spot a covered receiver who can’t go out for a pass.
- Name each receiver by his letter (X, Y, Z, H, F) and by where he stands (split end, flanker, slot, wing, in-line), and say why each spot exists.
- Tell under center, pistol and shotgun apart, read where the back stands, and say what each alignment gives up.
- Read a receiver’s split against the field’s landmarks (the hash, the numbers, the sideline) and say what it makes easy or hard for him.
- Declare a formation’s strength the way an offense would, and the ways a defense might, and explain why the two can disagree.
- Explain how a lineman becomes a receiver by reporting eligible, what the Patriots did with that rule in January 2015, and how the league changed it for the 2015 season.

Why formations have rules at all

Football’s earliest offenses were rugby scrums with a quarterback. Players bunched into wedges, linked arms and drove the ball carrier forward as a pile. The game was violent, and after a string of deaths in the early 1900s the rule-makers spent several years trying to open it up. They legalized the forward pass in 1906, and in 1910 they required the offense to put **seven players on the line of scrimmage**, which ended the mass formations that had hidden the worst violence inside a pile.¹ The NFL, founded in 1920, inherited that framework, and its rulebook still starts every play the same way.

Those rules also do a quieter job, and it is the one that matters for watching games today: **they let the defense count**. At the snap, the defense needs to know which offensive players can catch a pass. Only five can, at most: the two players at the ends of the line and the players in the backfield. Five interior linemen will not be running routes, so nobody has to cover them. A defensive coordinator plans the whole coverage on that fact. The formation rules guarantee it, and the uniform numbers announce it, so a defender can see who is eligible before the snap without being told.

Every rule in this chapter is a trade between those two goals. The offense gets a lot of freedom in where it puts its players. The defense gets a guarantee about who can catch the ball. When an offense finds a gap between those two guarantees, the league usually closes it, and we will see it happen.

The rules of the line

The NFL rulebook’s requirements for the offense at the snap fit on an index card.²

1. **At least seven players on the line.** More is legal; fewer is not.

¹The 1906 and 1910 rule reforms (legal forward pass; seven men on the line of scrimmage; the end of mass and interlocking formations): Elmer Berry, *The Forward Pass in Football* (1921), Project Gutenberg: <https://gutenberg.org/files/33120/33120-h/33120-h.htm> ; Green Bay Packers, “Would the 1906 rule changes banning the turtle-back wedge apply to the tush push?”: <https://www.packers.com/news/would-the-1906-rule-changes-banning-the-turtle-back-wedge-apply-to-the-tush-push> .

²NFL, *2026 Official Playing Rules*, Rule 7, Section 5, Article 1 (position of players at the snap: seven or more on the line; eligible receivers on both ends; no player neither clearly on nor clearly off the line; eligible positions need eligible numbers; penalty for illegal formation, five yards) and Rule 7, Section 4, Article 8 (one backfield player may be in motion, parallel to or away from the line): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>

2. **The players at both ends of the line must be eligible receivers**, and everyone between them on the line is ineligible.
3. **Nobody may be “half on” the line.** A player is either clearly on it or clearly off it. (The one exception is the quarterback directly behind the center.)
4. **Players in eligible spots must wear eligible numbers** (0–49 or 80–89), unless they have reported a change to the referee. Linemen wear 50–79.³
5. Everyone must be set and still for a full second before the snap, except one backfield player who may be in motion parallel to the line or away from it. Motion has its own chapter; for now, just notice that the rule says *backfield* player.

That gives us our first two terms. A player is **on the line** when he is facing downfield and his helmet breaks the plane of the center’s beltline, an imaginary line across the field at the center’s waist. A player is **off the line** when he is clearly behind that plane; to be an eligible receiver from there, he must be at least a yard behind the line.⁴ The difference between “on” and “off” is often a single step, but it is not a matter of taste: it decides whether the player is part of the line, where only the two ends are eligible, or a back, who is eligible.

So who is eligible? Combine the rules and you get a neat result. Of the eleven players, seven are on the line. The two at the ends are eligible; the five between them are not. The other four are off the line, and all four are eligible, provided they wear eligible numbers and stand at least a yard deep. That is six possible receivers. The quarterback usually takes one of those slots, and if he is directly under the center (the rulebook calls him a **T-formation quarterback**, anyone within a yard of the snapper), he is *not* eligible unless he moves to a legal receiver spot and holds still there for a second before the snap.⁵ So against a normal under-center offense the defense counts five eligible receivers, and against a shotgun quarterback it technically has six to worry about. That is why trick plays in which the quarterback catches a pass, like the Eagles’ “Philly Special” touchdown to Nick Foles in Super Bowl LII, start with the quarterback away from the center.⁶

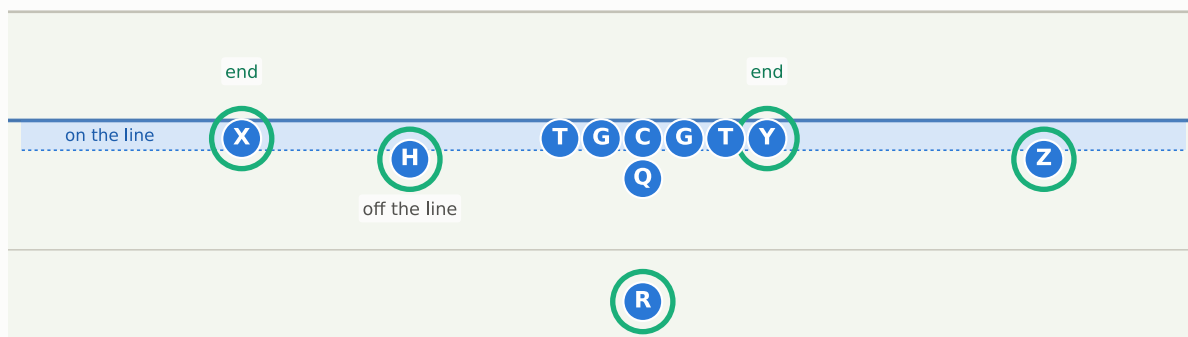
³NFL, *2026 Official Playing Rules*, Rule 5, Section 1, Article 2 (players numbered by position; eligible receivers and a T-formation quarterback wear 0–49 or 80–89; offensive linemen 50–79). Numbers changed for some positions in 2021 and 2023; the eligible/ineligible bands did not.

⁴NFL, *2026 Official Playing Rules*, Rule 3, Section 18, Article 3 (a player on the line has his shoulders facing the opponent’s goal line and his helmet breaking the plane of the snapper’s beltline) and Rule 8, Section 1, Articles 5–6 (eligible receivers: ends of the line, and players legally at least one yard behind it, with eligible numbers or having reported).

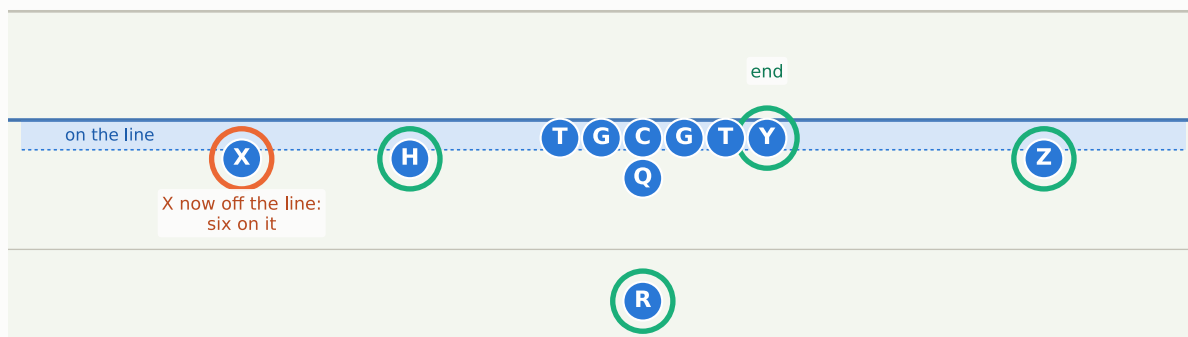
⁵NFL, *2026 Official Playing Rules*, Rule 3, Section 42 (a T-formation quarterback is a player aligned one yard or less behind the snapper) and Rule 8, Section 1, Article 6(d) (he is ineligible unless, before the snap, he moves to a spot at least a yard behind the line or at the end of the line and is stationary there for a second).

⁶Super Bowl LII, February 4, 2018 (Eagles 41, Patriots 33): on fourth-and-goal late in the first half the snap went directly to running back Corey Clement, who pitched to tight end Trey Burton, who threw a touchdown pass to quarterback Nick Foles: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Philly_Special

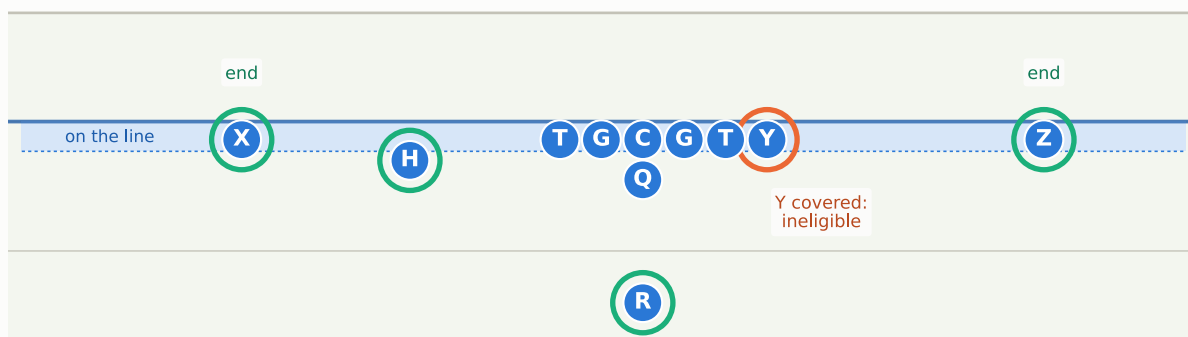
A • Legal: seven on the line, so X and Y are the ends



B • Illegal formation: X steps back, and only six are on the line



C • Legal, but Y is covered: Z on the line outside him becomes the end



○ eligible receiver ○ the player whose alignment changed

Figure 1: Three versions of one formation. The shaded strip is the line: a player whose helmet reaches into it is on the line. (A) Seven on the line (X, five linemen, Y), so X and Y are the ends and eligible, and H, Z and the back are eligible from the backfield. (B) X takes one step back. Now only six are on the line: illegal formation, five yards. (C) Z steps up onto the line outside Y. Eight on the line is legal, but Z is now the end, so Y is covered and can't catch a pass. Green rings: eligible receivers. Orange: the player whose step changed the picture.

The covered receiver

Panel C is the one fans miss. A tight end usually lines up on the line next to the tackle, and normally he is the end on his side, so he is eligible. But if a wide receiver on that side *also* lines up on the line, outside him, the receiver becomes the end. The tight end is now an interior player on the line: a **covered receiver**, “covered up” by his teammate. He keeps his eligible number, but by position he is ineligible. If he catches a forward pass it is a foul (illegal touching), and if he wanders more than a yard downfield before a pass is thrown, it is illegal man downfield.

Offenses cover their own players on purpose all the time. On a run, the tight end is a blocker anyway, and putting the receiver on the line changes nothing for him. Covering a receiver is also how an offense fixes its count: if the outside receiver needs to be on

the line to make seven, someone inside him gets covered. And it creates a tell for you. **When the receiver outside a tight end steps up onto the line, that tight end is not going out for a pass.**

i Madden vs. real life

In a video game you pick a formation from a menu and it is legal by construction: nobody can line up a step too deep. On a real field, alignment is something players have to get right on every snap. Receivers often check with the official on their sideline (“am I on or off?”), and the officials will tell them, because the officials would rather fix a formation than flag it. Watch the outside receivers before a snap and you will see the glance and the little point from the official.

What breaks the rules, and what it costs

An **illegal formation** is a five-yard penalty. The usual causes are the ones in the figure: six on the line because a receiver lined up a step too deep; an eligible-numbered player at an interior spot without reporting; a lineman at the end of the line who hasn’t reported; or a “tweener” who is neither clearly on nor clearly off the line. (Too many players in the backfield is the same foul in disguise, since it means fewer than seven on the line.) A few related fouls come from the same rules but are called after the snap: illegal touching when an ineligible player catches a pass, and illegal man downfield when an ineligible lineman gets too far past the line before a pass. They belong to the passing game, and we’ll meet them there.

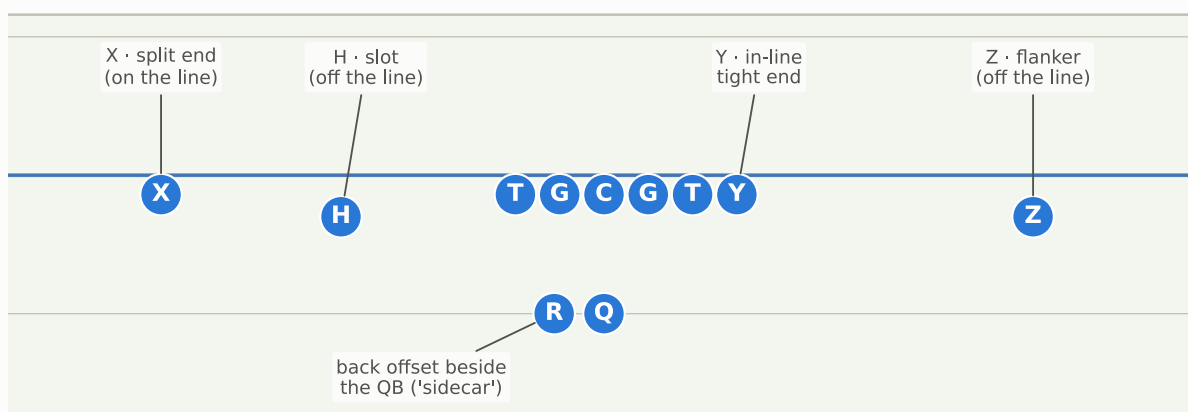
! Why it exists: the count

The rules make one promise to the defense: **at most five eligible receivers against an under-center quarterback, and you can see who they are.** Ends and backs, with the right numbers. That promise is what lets a defense call a coverage at all. It also limits the offense: a team that wants six blockers has to give up a receiver, and a team that wants five receivers has to protect with five linemen. Every formation is a choice about how to spend those eleven players under those rules.

Naming the players: X, Y, Z, H and F

Coaches need a name for every spot, so they can say “you line up there” in one syllable. The NFL mostly uses letters, and the core three come straight from the formation rules.

2x2 (shotgun, 11 personnel)



3x1 (under center, 12 personnel)

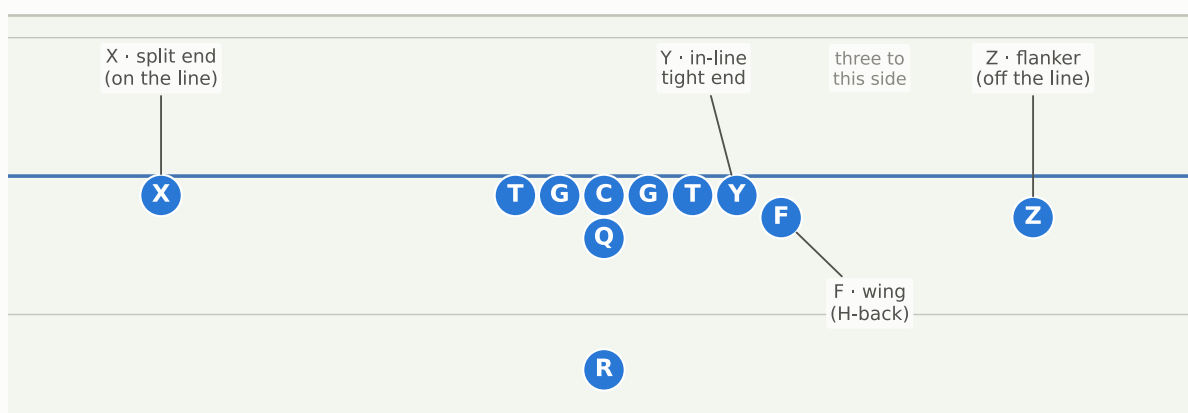


Figure 2: The letters on two common formations. Top: a 2x2 from the shotgun, 11 personnel (two receivers each side). X is on the line, the end on the left; Z is off the line, outside the tight end; H is the slot on the left. Bottom: three receivers right and one left (a 3x1), under center, 12 personnel. The second tight end, F, stands as a wing: just outside Y and a yard off the line, so Y is still the end. Letters are the most common NFL usage, not a law; teams' dialects differ.

The **X receiver**, also called the **split end**, lines up **on the line**, usually on the side away from the tight end. The name is literal: he is the *end* of the line, *split* out wide. Why must he be on the line? Count. Five linemen plus a tight end on one side make six; the offense needs a seventh, and it needs an eligible end on the other side. The X is that player. The cost is that being on the line means a cornerback can line up right in his face and jam him at the snap, and he can't go in motion without first resetting (only a backfield player may be moving at the snap). So the X is often a big, strong receiver who can beat press coverage, and in a 3x1 formation he is frequently alone on his side: the **backside X**, isolated against one cornerback.

The **Z receiver**, or **flanker**, lines up **off the line**, usually on the tight end's side. Because the tight end is that side's end, the Z doesn't need to be on the line, so he steps back a yard and becomes, legally, a back. That yard buys him two things: he is harder to jam (a defender in his face has less of him to grab), and he can go in motion. The Z is the offense's most common motion man, which you will see constantly in motion and shifts.

The flanker has a human origin. In 1949 the Los Angeles Rams' head coach, Clark Shaughnessy, moved Elroy "Crazylegs" Hirsch, a former halfback whose career had been threatened by injury, out from the backfield to a spot wide of the formation and a step back. In 1951 Hirsch caught passes for 1,495 yards and 17 touchdowns as the Rams won the championship. He is generally credited as the pro game's first true flanker, and the spot became standard within a decade.⁷

The **Y receiver** is, in most NFL playbooks, the main tight end. When he lines up on the line next to the tackle he is an **in-line tight end**: close enough to block like a sixth lineman, but still the end, so still eligible. (Some offenses, especially spread and Air

⁷ *Encyclopaedia Britannica*, "Elroy Hirsch" (moved from halfback to end by Clark Shaughnessy in 1949; 1,495 receiving yards and 17 touchdowns in 1951; "the pro game's first true flanker"): <https://www.britannica.com/biography/Elroy-Hirsch> ; Pro Football Hall of Fame biography (inducted 1968): <https://www.profootballhof.com/players/elroy-hirsch/>

Raid systems that rarely use a tight end, use Y for a slot receiver instead.) When the tight end lines up off the line or split out like a receiver, coaches call him “detached” or “flexed”; he is still Y, just standing somewhere else.

That leaves the **H and F**: the move players. They are the flexible fourth and fifth eligible receivers, and what they are depends on personnel. In 11 personnel (one back, one tight end) H is usually the third wide receiver, playing the slot. In 12 or 21 personnel, H or F is the second tight end, an H-back or the fullback. Which letter is which varies by team: some use F for the fullback and H for the H-back; some use U for the second tight end, as in our other chapters’ diagrams. Ask a coach and he will say the letter is whatever *his* playbook says it is, which is a reminder that this is team language, not a rule. Nobody has a clean birth certificate for X, Y and Z either; they were in common use by the 1960s, and attributions to particular coaches are guesses.

Where they stand: slot, wing and backfield spots

Three more words describe *where* a player lines up, whatever his letter.

- The **slot** is the space between the formation (the tackle, or the tight end) and the widest receiver on that side, and the receiver who lines up there. A slot receiver is usually off the line. He has room to break either way, a two-way go, and he often faces a linebacker or a safety instead of a cornerback, which is why the slot has become one of the most valuable spots in the modern passing game.
- A **wing** is a spot just outside the end man on the line and a yard or so behind him: close enough to block at the edge, off the line so that the end inside him stays eligible. The F in the bottom panel is a wing.
- The **backfield** spots (fullback, tailback, H-back) are named by their depth and offset, which comes next.

Where the quarterback stands

The quarterback’s alignment is the biggest single choice in a formation, because it shapes the snap, the run game and the pass game at once. There are three main options.

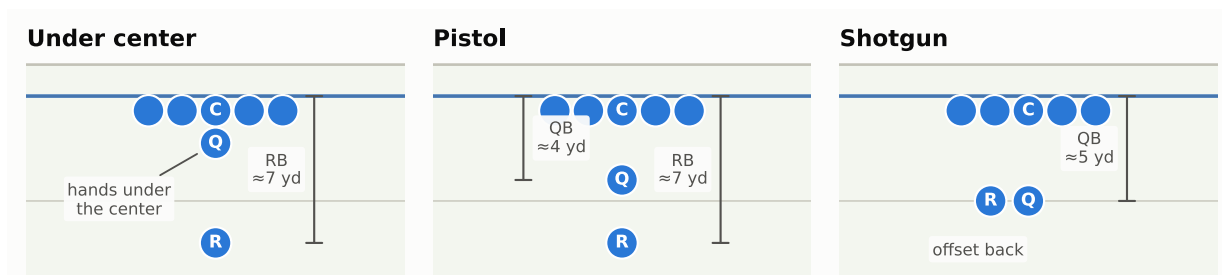


Figure 3: The three quarterback alignments, with typical NFL depths. Under center: the quarterback takes the snap hand to hand (drawn slightly deeper than life so the markers don’t overlap) and the back is about seven yards deep. Pistol: the quarterback at about four yards, the back directly behind him. Shotgun: the quarterback at about five yards, here with the back offset beside him. Depths vary by team and by play.

Under center means the quarterback puts his hands directly beneath the center and takes the ball hand to hand. It is the oldest alignment and still the best one for some jobs. The snap is nearly foolproof and instantaneous, so the quarterback can turn and hand off on the same rhythm as the linemen’s first step. With his back to the defense for a moment, he hides the ball, and play-action fakes look exactly like runs. The back stands six to eight yards deep, directly behind the quarterback, so he can go either way, and his alignment tells the defense nothing. The cost is time and sight: on a pass, the quarterback must drop three, five or seven steps while turning his back on the defense, and he gets his first look at the coverage a beat later than he would from the shotgun.

The **shotgun** puts the quarterback about five yards deep, and the center snaps the ball to him through the air. He sees the whole defense from the moment of the snap and is already at passing depth, which buys time against a pass rush. That was exactly the problem it was invented to solve. San Francisco’s coach Red Hickey, facing the Baltimore Colts’ fierce pass rush, unveiled it on November 27, 1960, with his quarterbacks taking the snap about seven yards deep. The 49ers abandoned it within a year, but Tom Landry’s Dallas Cowboys revived it in 1975 with Roger Staubach about five yards back, and by the 2010s it was the NFL’s default.⁸ The costs: a snap through the air can go wrong, the quarterback can’t easily hide the ball on a run, and the running back usually stands *beside* him, not behind. That last point matters for a viewer. A shotgun back is an **offset back**, lined up to one side of the

⁸Pro Football Hall of Fame, “The Shotgun Formation” (Hickey’s first use against the Colts on November 27, 1960, with quarterbacks seven yards deep; Landry’s 1975 revival): <https://profootballhof.com/news/the-shotgun-formation> ; Fox Sports/AP, “Staubach recalls when Landry installed shotgun for Cowboys” (about five yards deep): <https://www.foxnews.com/sports/staubach-recalls-when-landry-installed-shotgun-for-cowboys>

quarterback (coaches sometimes call this the “sidecar” spot), and on many inside runs he crosses the quarterback’s face to run to the other side. A defense that knows a team’s habits can read a lot from which side the back is on.

The **pistol** splits the difference: the quarterback about four yards deep, the back directly behind him. Chris Ault designed it at the University of Nevada in 2005 because he wanted shotgun vision without giving up a downhill, either-direction run game.⁹ The back can go either way again, the quarterback is still deep enough to see, and the read-option game (in which the quarterback reads a defender and keeps or hands off) works naturally from it. The cost is that it is neither as quick to pass from as the shotgun nor as good for hiding the ball as under center. In the NFL it is a seasoning, not a staple, used heavily by a few teams and barely by most.

Under center, the back can also be offset. The **offset I**, with the fullback a step to one side of the quarterback, is the classic example, and it gets its own plate in Classic Formations.

How do teams actually split these? FTN’s charters record the quarterback’s alignment on every play, which lets us see how differently NFL offenses are built.

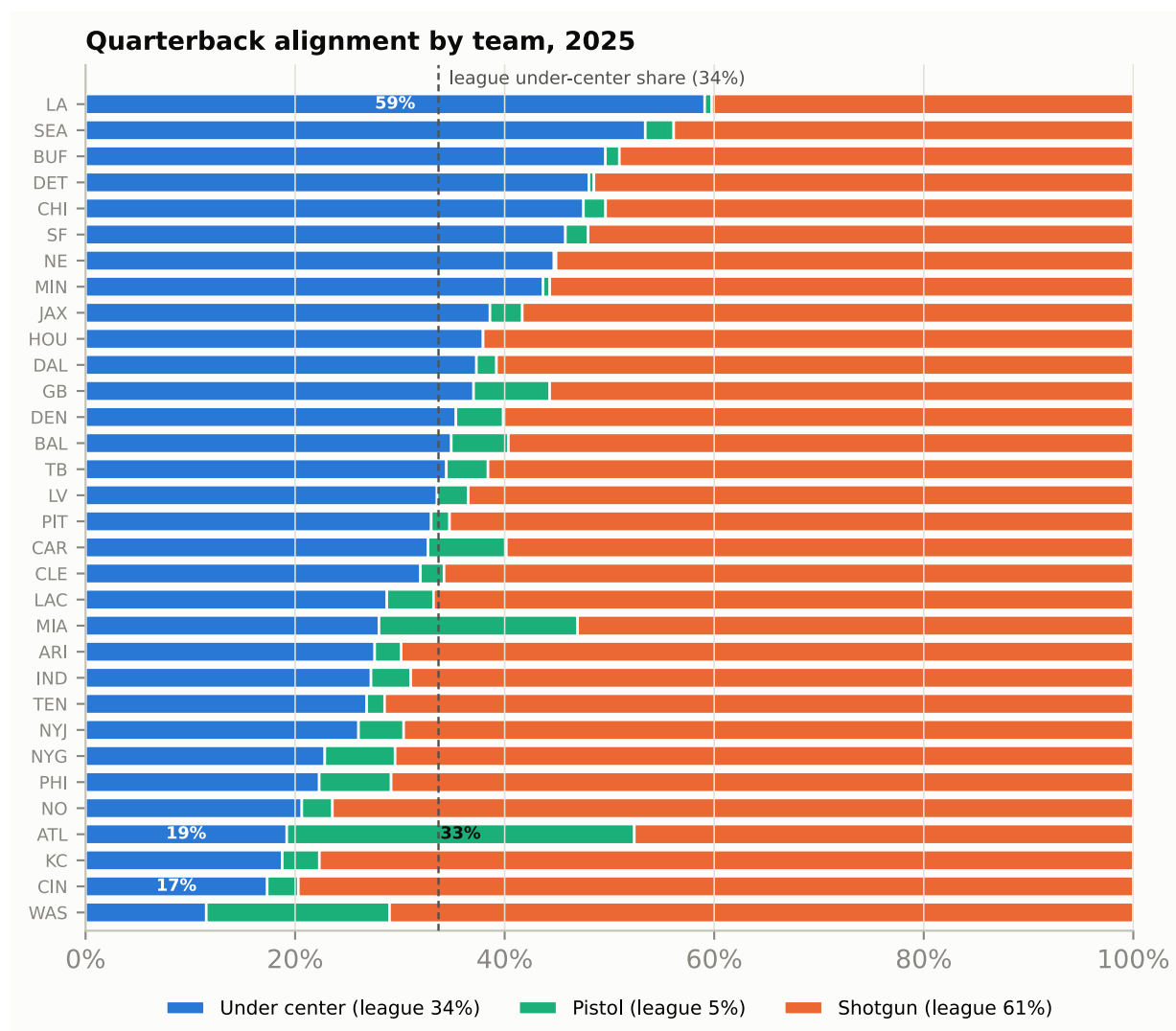


Figure 4: Where each team’s quarterback lined up, 2025 regular season (runs and passes). Sorted by the share of snaps under center. The Rams took more than half their snaps under center; several teams barely used it. Pistol is a specialist’s tool: a few teams (Atlanta, Miami, Washington) used it on a sixth to a third of their snaps, and most used it on fewer than one in twenty. Source: FTN charting via nflverse (qb_location), joined to nflverse play-by-play.

League-wide in 2025, about a third of snaps came from under center, about three in five from the shotgun, and one in twenty

⁹CBS Sports, “Retracing the steps of the pistol” (Ault and his Nevada staff designing the pistol in spring 2005; quarterback about four yards deep, back behind him): <https://www.cbssports.com/college-football/news/retracing-the-steps-of-the-pistol> ; see also https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Pistol_offense

from the pistol.¹⁰ The spread between teams is the real lesson: the Rams and the Bengals play the same sport with almost opposite habits. When you watch a team for the first time, the quarterback's depth on the first few snaps tells you what kind of offense you are watching. The rise, fall and partial return of the under-center offense is the story of Classic Formations.

Splits and landmarks

Once the quarterback and backs are set, the receivers' positions are described by their **split**: how far they line up from the formation. Coaches rarely say "line up 14.6 yards from the ball." They name a landmark painted on the field, because the ball isn't always in the middle and landmarks don't move.

Two landmarks matter most. The **hash marks** are the two rows of short lines where the ball is spotted when a play ends near a sideline (the field covered them). In the NFL they are 70 feet 9 inches from each sideline, about 23.6 yards in, which leaves only about six yards between them. **The numbers** are the big yard-line numerals: by rule their bottoms sit 12 yards in from each sideline and they are two yards tall, so they run from 12 to 14 yards in.¹¹ "On the numbers," "top of the numbers" (the edge nearer the middle) and "bottom of the numbers" (the edge nearer the sideline) are everyday instructions.

¹⁰Course calculation from nflverse data (downloaded 2026-10-06): FTN charting `qb_location` (U = under center, S = shotgun, P = pistol) joined to regular-season play-by-play runs and passes with a down recorded, 2025. League shares: shotgun 61.3%, under center 33.6%, pistol 4.9%. Highest under-center share: Rams 59.1%; lowest: Bengals 17.3%. Highest pistol share: Falcons 33.1%. The under-center figure matches the course fact sheet (§10).

¹¹NFL, *2026 Official Playing Rules*, Rule 1, Section 1, Article 2 (inbounds lines, the hash marks, 70 feet 9 inches from each sideline) and Article 4 (field numerals: bottoms 12 yards in from each sideline, two yards tall). The rulebook's field notes give college hashes as 60 feet from the sideline.

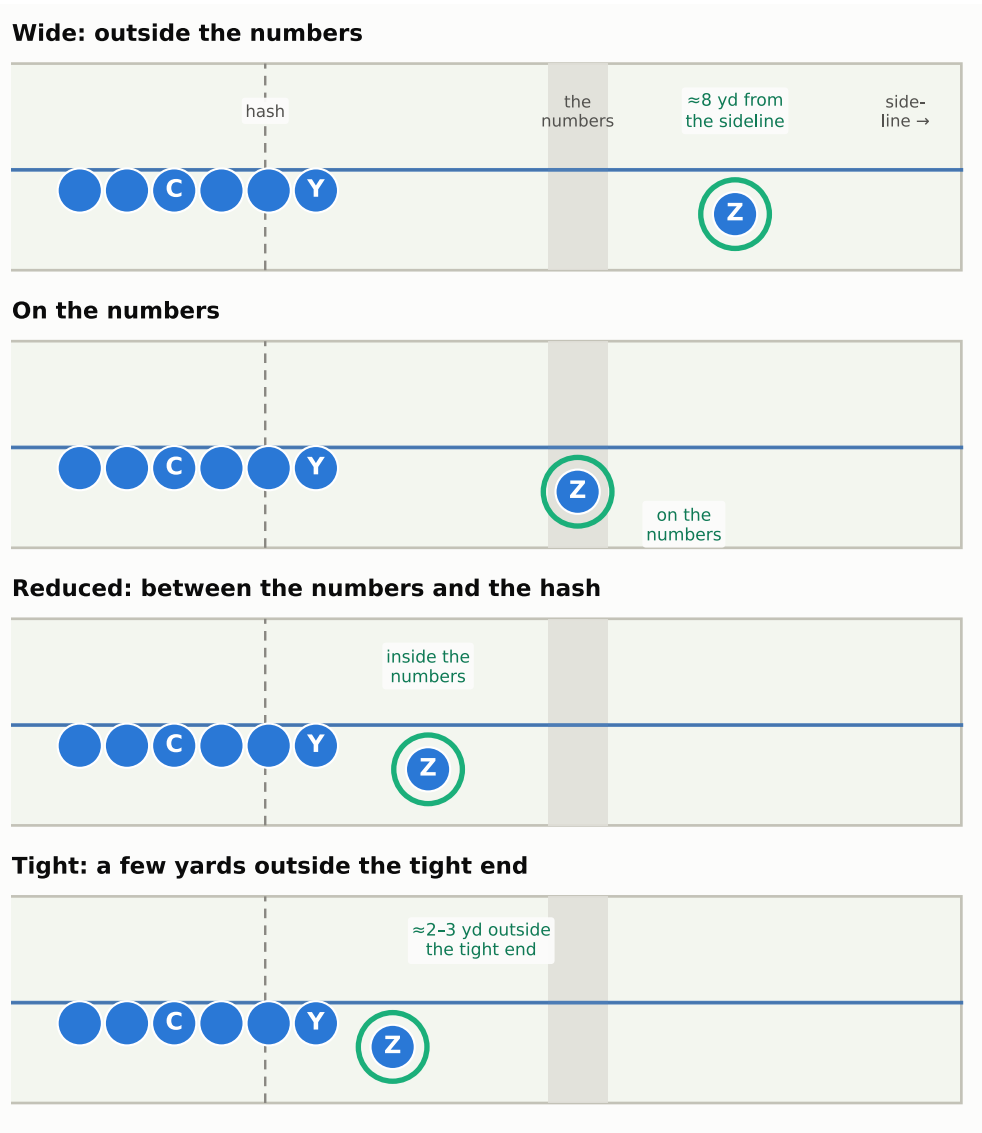


Figure 5: The split ladder: one receiver (Z, off the line) on the right side of the formation at four common splits, ball in the middle of the field. Wide: outside the numbers, about eight yards from the sideline. On the numbers: the standard split. Reduced: inside the numbers, between them and the hash. Tight: a few yards outside the tight end, the alignment of condensed formations. Shaded band: the painted numbers (12–14 yards from the sideline); dashed line: the hash.

A receiver's split is not decoration. It decides how much room he has, and in which direction.

- **Wide** (outside the numbers): lots of room inside him, little outside. Good for inside-breaking routes (slants, digs) and for stretching the defense horizontally, so the defenders in the middle have more ground to cover. The sideline becomes a twelfth defender on anything breaking outside.
- **On the numbers**: the standard split. Room both ways.
- A **reduced split** (inside the numbers, toward the formation): now he has room *outside*, for outs, corners and fades, and he is close enough to the formation to block back inside on a run (the crack block of perimeter runs).
- **Tight** (a few yards outside the tight end or tackle): the alignment of the condensed formations that modern offenses love. It gives the receiver a two-way go, puts him in position to block like a tight end, and lets receivers cross and rub defenders off each other.

That is why splits are a tell, with a big caveat. A receiver who suddenly lines up in a tight or reduced split may be doing it to block, or to run an outside-breaking route he couldn't run from a wide split. Good offenses know defenses chart this, so they vary splits on purpose, sometimes running the same route from three different splits to break the habit. Treat a split as a clue, never a guarantee.

The hash and the wide side

Because the ball is spotted on a hash after any play that ends near a sideline, most snaps are not in the middle of the field. The side with more room is the field side, or wide side; the side with less is the boundary, or short side. In the NFL the difference is smaller than you might think: from a hash, the near sideline is about 23.6 yards away and the far one about 29.7. (College hashes sit 60 feet from each sideline, so the college boundary is much shorter, and the field-boundary distinction rules college defenses more.) Even six yards matters: a receiver to the boundary has less room to work, and a defense can lean on the sideline as help.

Formation strength

Every defense needs to know, before the snap, which side of the formation to treat as strong, because its front, its linebackers and its coverage are all built to set to one side. The offense thinks about the same question from the other direction. **Formation strength** is the side a team treats as strong, and the striking thing is that it is not a fact about the formation. It is a **rule** a team agrees on, and different rules give different answers.

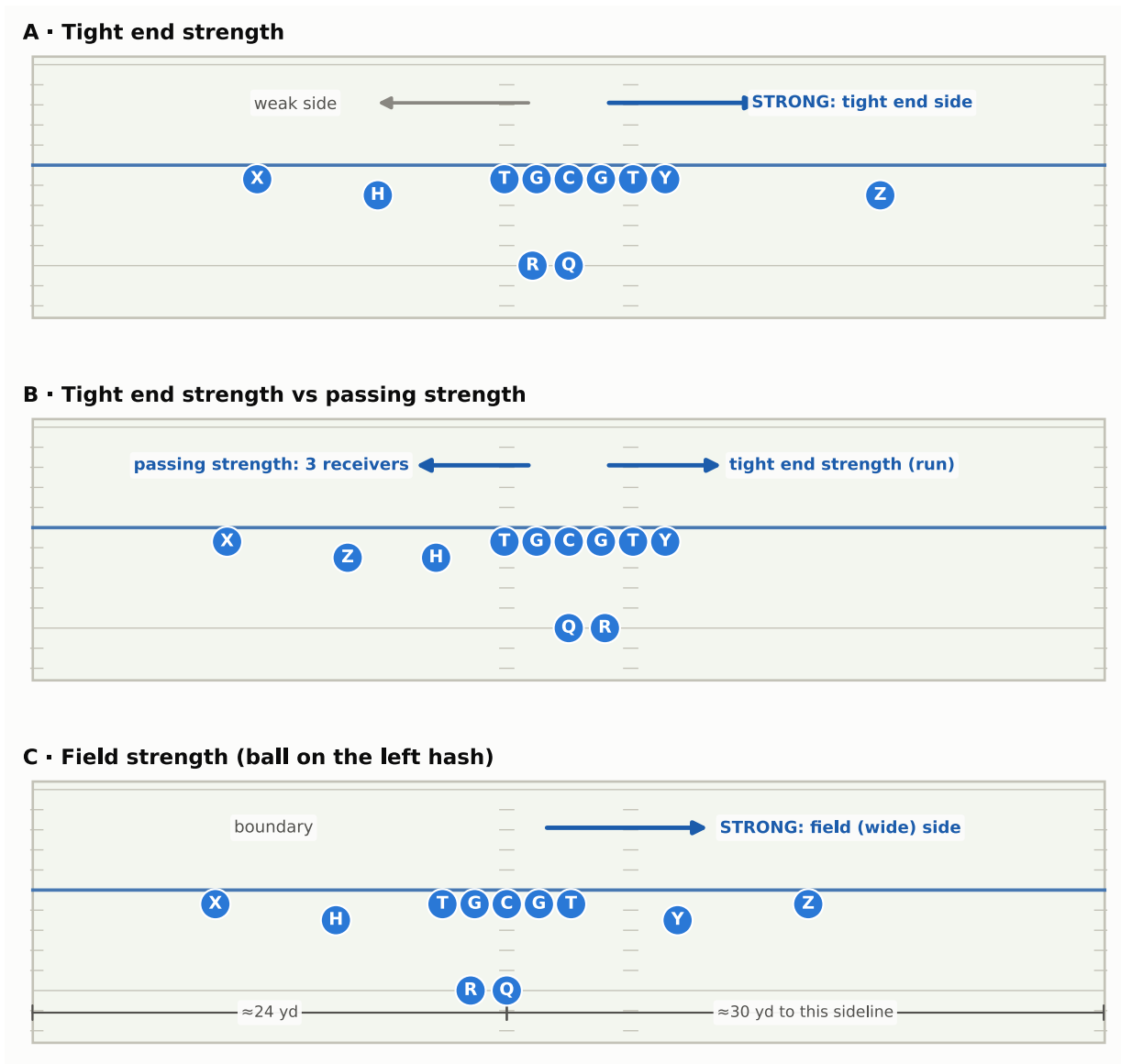


Figure 6: Three ways to declare the strong side. (A) Tight end strength: the in-line tight end's side is strong, the side a run defense must respect. (B) Passing strength: three receivers left, the tight end alone on the right. By the tight-end rule, strength is right; by receiver count, left. Defenses often answer with both: the front sets to the tight end, the coverage to the three receivers. (C) Field strength: a balanced 2x2 with no in-line tight end, the ball on the left hash. Nothing in the formation says which side is strong, so the defense uses the field: the wide side (right) is strong.

The common rules are these.

- **Tight end strength.** The **strong side** is the in-line tight end's side, and the **weak side** is the other. This is the oldest rule and still the default in conversation ("he ran to the strong side"). It is a run-game rule: the tight end is an extra blocker, so that side has more gaps to defend and more muscle at the point of attack. Defenses traditionally put their Sam linebacker and their strong safety to that side: the names literally mean the "strong-side" linebacker and safety.
- **Passing strength** (receiver strength). The strong side is the side with more eligible receivers spread out. It is a pass-defense rule: three receivers on one side is the bigger coverage problem. In a 3x1 formation the passing strength is the three-receiver side, whatever the tight end does.
- **Field strength.** When the formation is balanced (two and two, no in-line tight end), the defense declares the strong side by the field: the wide side, or occasionally the boundary, by its own rule. Some defenses set *everything* to the field, regardless of formation, so that the front never has to shift.
- **Back strength.** Some teams break ties with the running back's side, or the fullback's offset.

The offense declares strength too, because its play calls depend on it. "Strong right" tells the tight end and the flanker where to go, and a run called "to the strong side" means the side the formation names.

! Why it exists: the defense must commit

A defense has eleven players and a front of four to six of them. It can't balance perfectly against every formation, so it has to lean, and the strength call decides which way. That is the offense's opportunity. **When the run strength and the pass strength point in opposite directions, as in panel B, the defense has to choose**, or split its call: the line and linebackers set to the tight end, the coverage rotates to the three receivers. Every split creates seams between the two halves of the call, and offenses build plays to attack them. The detail is in Even Fronts and in split-field coverage.

🔥 Common misconception

"The strong side is the side with more players." Sometimes. But it's a rule a *team* chooses, and two teams looking at the same formation can call opposite sides strong. In panel B, the offense may call it "strong right" (the tight end) while the defense calls "trips left" (the receivers). Neither is wrong. What matters to you is which side the defense *treated* as strong, and you can see that: watch which way the defensive front shifts and where the safeties rotate.

The strength call is also why motion is so useful. Move a tight end or a receiver from one side to the other before the snap and the strength flips, so the defense must re-declare it with the play clock running down. Some defenses shift their whole front, some just move a safety, and some don't adjust at all. Each answer tells the offense something, which is the subject of Motion and Shifts.

Reporting eligible: when a lineman becomes a receiver

The number rule has an escape hatch, and it is the most surprising rule in this chapter. A player wearing an ineligible number (50–79 or 90–99) may line up in an eligible spot, at the end of the line or in the backfield, if he first tells the referee. That is **reporting eligible**. The referee then informs the defense, and in the NFL he does it over the stadium microphone: "Number 70 is reporting as eligible." The player must keep that status for as long as he is on the field, reporting before every snap, and he can go back to normal only after a timeout, a quarter break, a score, a change of possession, or a play on the sideline.¹² An eligible-numbered player can go the other way and report *ineligible*, lining up as a lineman.

¹²NFL, *2026 Official Playing Rules*, Rule 5, Section 3, Article 1 (reporting a change of position to the referee, who informs the defense; must report before each play while continuously in the game) and Article 2 (returning to the original position after a timeout, the end of a quarter, the two-minute warning, a foul, a replay review, a touchdown, a kick, a change of possession, or after being withdrawn for one snap; failing to report is a five-yard illegal substitution foul).

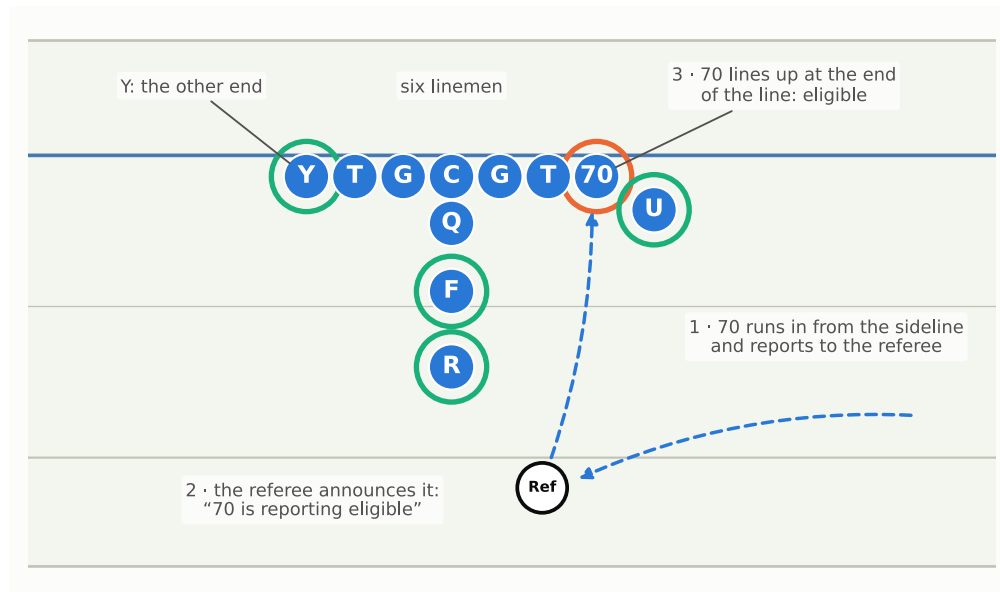


Figure 7: Reporting eligible, in a jumbo formation (six offensive linemen). Number 70, a lineman, runs in from the sideline, tells the referee he is eligible, and lines up at the right end of the line. The referee announces it to the defense. Seven players are on the line (Y, five linemen, 70); Y and 70 are the ends and eligible, as are the wing (U) and the two backs. A lineman who reports eligible and lines up at the end is called an eligible tackle.

Why would anyone want this? The answer is the same trade that runs through the whole chapter: blockers versus receivers.

The first use is **jumbo**: a personnel grouping with a sixth (or seventh) offensive lineman. Most often the extra lineman lines up where a tight end would, and since he is at the end of the line, he must report. The point is an extra 300-pound blocker at the edge on a run, someone a defensive end can't push around the way he might a tight end. The announcement is the price: the referee has just told the defense exactly who is eligible, and the defense will treat him as a receiver it barely needs to cover.

The second use is the surprise. An **eligible tackle** (or **tackle-eligible**) is a lineman who has reported and lines up at the end, and every so often he is the target: a play-action pass at the goal line, when the defense has bitten on the run and nobody covers the big man drifting into the end zone. It works precisely because it is rare. After the defense has seen the lineman block on the previous five announcements, the sixth one is a decoy it stops worrying about.

¹³ESPN/ABC News, "NFL says Pats' substitutions legal" (January 2015): three plays on the second third-quarter drive, four offensive linemen, Vereen or Hoomanawanui declared ineligible, drive ending in a five-yard touchdown pass to Gronkowski; Harbaugh's "clearly deception" and his unsportsmanlike-conduct penalty: <https://abc7news.com/post/nfl-says-pats-substitutions-legal/470636/> ; Deadspin, "The Patriots annoyed John Harbaugh by having fun with eligible receivers" (Hoomanawanui at left tackle, Vereen ineligible on the right, all three plays completed): <https://deadspin.com/the-patriots-annoyed-john-harbaugh-by-having-fun-with-e-1678818453>

¹⁴ESPN/ABC News, "Tom Brady: Study the rulebook" (January 2015): <https://abc13.com/post/tom-brady-study-the-rulebook/470281/>

The game: the divisional round after the 2014 season, played on January 10, 2015, in Foxborough. New England fell behind by 14 points twice and won 35–31.

What happened: on the Patriots' second drive of the third quarter, Bill Belichick and offensive coordinator Josh McDaniels used a formation with only **four** offensive linemen. Tight end Michael Hoomanawanui (number 47) lined up at the left-tackle spot, the end of the line, which made him eligible; running back Shane Vereen (number 34) reported as *ineligible* and lined up on the right side, inside the end, where a receiver would normally stand. Tom Brady took the offense to the line and snapped the ball quickly, and the Ravens' defenders struggled to work out who was eligible. They ran it three times on that drive, all three were completions, and the drive ended in a five-yard touchdown pass to Rob Gronkowski.¹³

The fallout: John Harbaugh ran onto the field to protest and was flagged for unsportsmanlike conduct. After the game he called it "clearly deception." The league said the plays were legal, and Brady's answer became the famous line: "Maybe those guys gotta study the rulebook and figure it out."¹⁴

What to notice: watch number 34. A running back standing where a slot receiver stands is someone a defense instinctively covers, and on at least one of the plays the Ravens' linebacker gave him room while he jogged *backward* at the snap, because he wasn't allowed past the line. Meanwhile number 47, lined up like a tackle, released up the field. Every defender's eyes went to the wrong man.

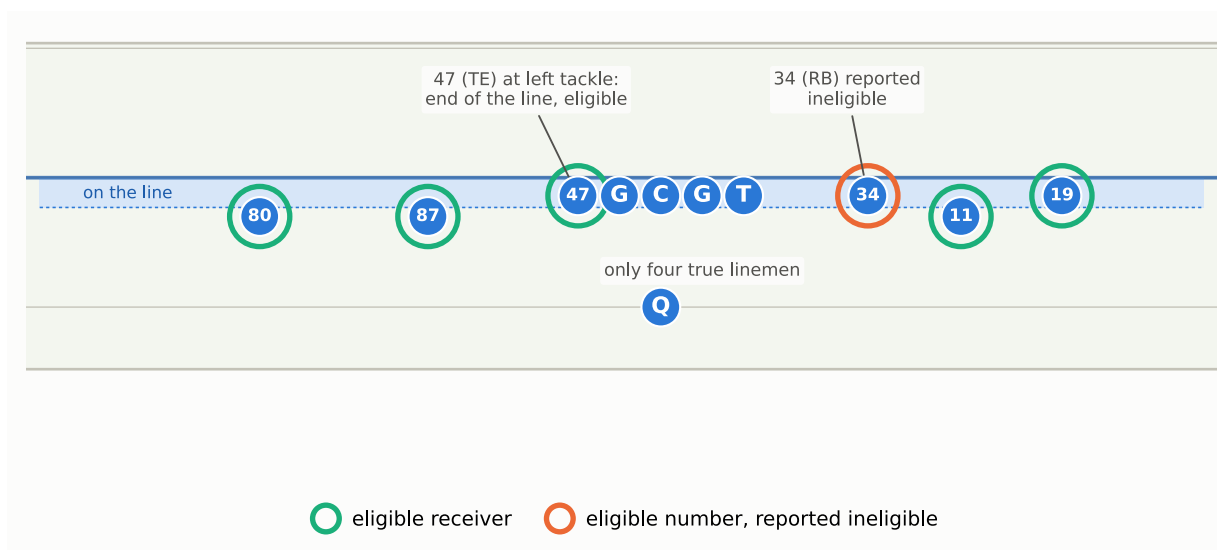


Figure 8: The Patriots' four-lineman formation, reconstructed from reports (exact splits are illustrative). Number 47, a tight end, lines up at the left-tackle spot: the end of the line, so eligible. Number 34, a running back, reports ineligible and stands on the line inside the right end, looking like a slot receiver. Seven on the line, five eligible receivers: perfectly legal under the 2014 rules.

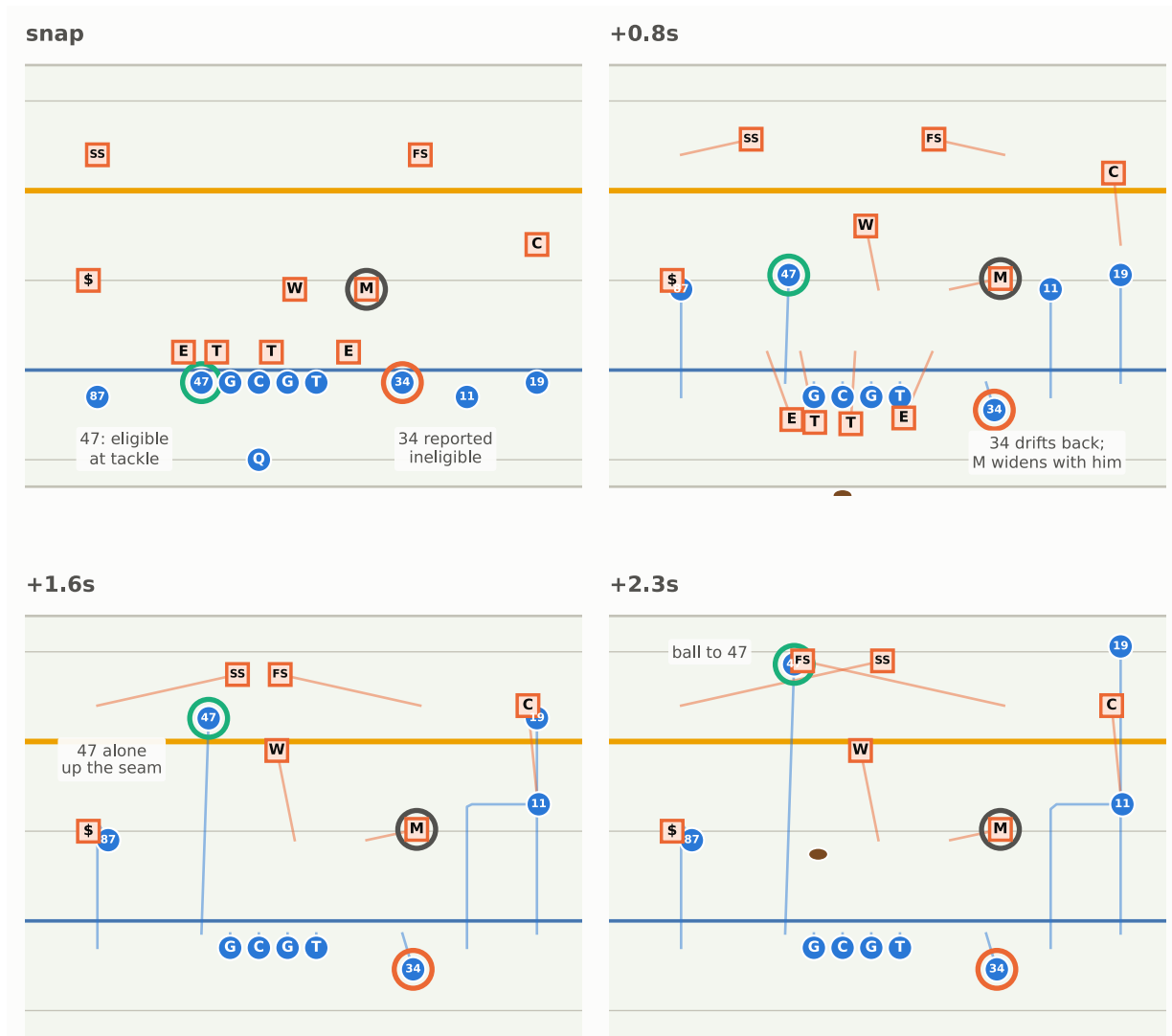


Figure 9: The same formation in motion (simulated, BDB-format tracking; illustrative timing and defense). At the snap, 34 drifts backward, because an ineligible player may not go past the line on a pass, while the linebacker over him widens to cover the ‘receiver’. Number 47 releases up the seam from the tackle spot into the space the linebacker left, and the ball goes to him. Rings: 47 green, 34 orange, the linebacker (M) gray; faint lines are each player’s path since the snap.

The league changed the rule before the next season. On March 25, 2015, the owners adopted a proposal that an eligible-numbered player who reports as ineligible must line up inside the tackle box, the “normal five-player core” between the tackles, or it is a five-yard foul.¹⁵ Today’s rulebook says it precisely: such a player must line up “within the normal five-player core formed by ineligible players and ... not more than two players removed from the middle player of a seven-player line.” A running back can still report ineligible and play guard; he can’t pretend to be a slot receiver any more. That is the pattern from the start of the chapter: an offense finds a gap between “the offense may line up anywhere” and “the defense can count,” and the league closes it.

The same January also produced the cleanest tackle-eligible touchdown of the era. In the AFC Championship Game a week later, left tackle Nate Solder reported eligible, lined up at his usual spot, blocked for a beat and then leaked out for a 16-yard touchdown pass from Brady. The NFL’s head of officiating later said the play should have been flagged, but not because of Solder: on the snap before, a different lineman, Cameron Fleming, had reported eligible, and he had then switched back to ineligible without leaving the field or waiting for a stoppage, which the reporting rule doesn’t allow.¹⁶ The rules are short, but they are exacting.

¹⁵ESPN, “New England Patriots formation now ruled illegal substitution” (March 25, 2015): https://africa.espn.com/nfl/story/_/id/12556985/new-england-patriots-formation-now-ruled-illegal-substitution ; *Sports Illustrated*, “Owners vote to ban Patriots’ ineligible receiver trick” (March 25, 2015): <https://www.si.com/nfl/2015/03/25/new-england-patriots-ineligible-receiver-trick-banned> . Current wording: NFL, *2026 Official Playing Rules*, Rule 5, Section 3, Articles 1–2.

¹⁶*Sports Illustrated*, “Watch: Patriots OT Nate Solder catches touchdown pass vs. Colts” (January 19, 2015; 16 yards, third quarter of the AFC Championship Game): <https://www.si.com/nfl/2015/01/19/patriots-colts-nate-solder-td-catch-afc-championship> ; *Sports Illustrated*, “NFL officiating head: Patriots

Film room: Lions 2023–2024 (Ben Johnson’s offense) — jumbo and the eligible tackle

The context: under offensive coordinator Ben Johnson (2022–2024), Detroit used six-lineman jumbo sets more than most offenses, usually with backup tackle Dan Skipper (number 70) reporting eligible as the extra man. At home the Ford Field crowd cheered every time the referee announced him, and he played a regular role in that package; in 2024 he caught a nine-yard touchdown pass against Buffalo.¹⁷

The game everyone remembers: at Dallas on December 30, 2023, the Lions scored with 23 seconds left to pull within 20–19 and went for two. Left tackle Taylor Decker caught the conversion pass, and it was wiped out: referee Brad Allen said that Skipper, not Decker, had reported eligible, so Decker was an ineligible receiver. The Lions insisted Decker had reported; the video seemed to show Decker approaching the referee, and quarterback Jared Goff said, “I do know that Decker reported. I do know that Dan Skipper did not.” Detroit’s retries failed and Dallas won 20–19.¹⁸ Whatever happened in that conversation, the play shows how much depends on a few seconds of reporting.

What to notice when you watch Detroit-era jumbo film: the referee’s announcement; where number 70 lines up (at the end of the line, usually beside the tackle, where a tight end would stand); and the defense’s response, which is usually more run defenders, not more coverage. Then watch for the rare snap when the announced lineman releases into a route. The first lesson of personnel applies: the defense always knows who is on the field. The offense’s bet is that it won’t believe it.

Putting it together: a five-second read

Everything in this chapter turns into a quick routine you can run in the time between the huddle breaking and the snap.

1. **Find the quarterback’s depth.** Under center, pistol or shotgun, and where the back stands beside or behind him.
2. **Count the line.** Are the receivers on the outside on or off the ball? Is any tight end covered? That tells you who can’t go out.
3. **Read the splits.** Wide, numbers, reduced, tight. Is anyone unusually tight?
4. **Call the strength.** The tight end’s side, then the receiver count. If they disagree, note both.
5. **Watch the defense answer.** Which way did the front set? Where did the safeties go?

Watch for it on Sunday: the strength caller

For one quarter, before every snap:

- **Say the strong side out loud** by the tight end rule (“strong right”). If there is no in-line tight end, use the receiver count; if the formation is balanced, use the wide side of the field.
- **If the receiver count points the other way**, say that too (“strong right, trips left”).
- **Then look at the defense:** which way did the defensive line and linebackers shift, and which side has the safety who walked down? Mark whether the defense set to *your* call.
- **Bonus:** any time you hear “reporting as eligible,” predict run or pass before the snap, and check.

After a quarter you will usually find that a defense follows one rule very consistently. Once you know its rule, you can predict its front from the formation alone.

scored touchdown on illegal play vs. Colts” (January 30, 2015; Dean Blandino on Cameron Fleming’s reporting): <https://www.si.com/nfl/2015/01/30/new-england-patriots-illegal-play-ineligible-receiver>

¹⁷ESPN, “Beloved Lions OL Dan Skipper to announce retirement from NFL” (January 2026; the Ford Field cheers when he reported eligible in the jumbo package, his 9-yard touchdown catch against Buffalo in 2024): https://africa.espn.com/nfl/story/_/id/47695668/beloved-lions-ol-dan-skipper-announce-retirement-nfl. Johnson was the Lions’ offensive coordinator from 2022 to 2024 and became the Bears’ head coach in 2025 (course fact sheet, \$0 and \$9).

¹⁸Associated Press, “Lions take issue with officials after potential winning 2-point pass is negated by penalty” (December 31, 2023), with Brad Allen’s pool report and the Goff and Campbell quotes: <https://www.news4jax.com/sports/2023/12/31/lions-take-issue-with-officials-after-potential-winning-2-point-pass-is-negated-by-penalty/>

Predict the play

💡 Predict the play 1: who can't go out?

Second-and-7 at midfield. The offense is in 12 personnel under center: the tight end Y is in-line on the right, the second tight end U is a wing on the left. Just before the snap, the flanker Z steps up from a yard off the line onto the line. How many eligible receivers does the offense have, who is no longer one, and what does that suggest about the play?

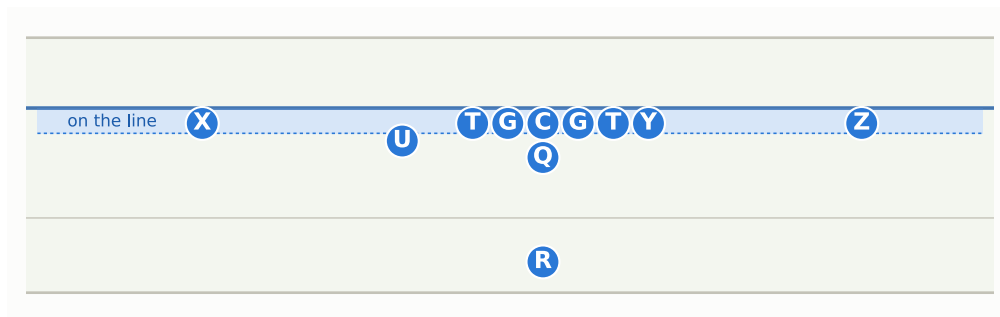


Figure 10: Drill 1: 12 personnel under center. Z (right) has just stepped up onto the line. Count the line, find the ends.

Answer 1 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play 2: the split call

First-and-10. The ball is on the right hash, so the wide side of the field is to the offense's left. The offense lines up with three receivers to the left (the field) and an in-line tight end alone on the right (the boundary), quarterback in the shotgun. Where is the strong side? Which way would you expect the defensive front to set, and which way the coverage?

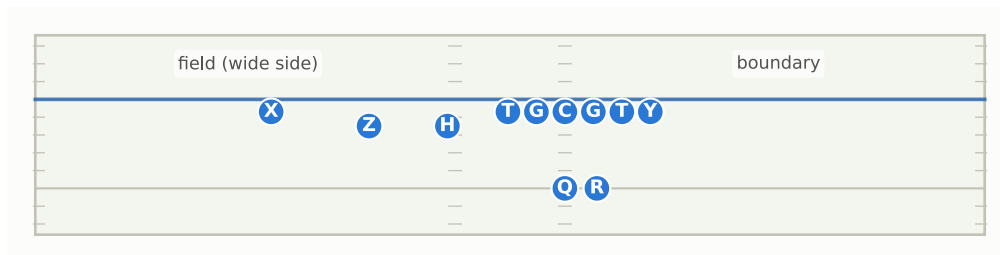


Figure 11: Drill 2: shotgun, 11 personnel, ball on the right hash. Three receivers to the field (left), the tight end in-line to the boundary (right).

Answer 2 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play 3: the announcement

Second-and-goal from the 2. The offense comes out with six offensive linemen, two tight ends and a fullback, quarterback under center. The referee announces, “Number 70 is reporting as eligible,” and 70 lines up at the right end of the line. Run or pass? And if it is a pass, who is the most likely target?

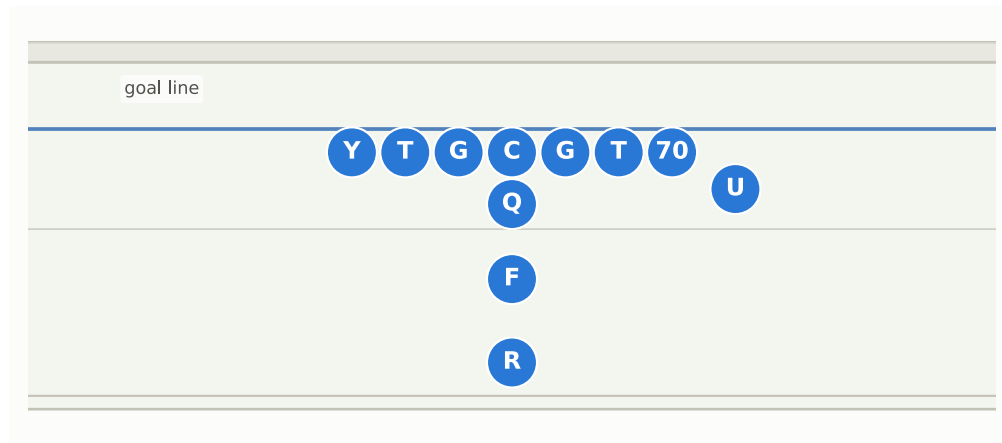


Figure 12: Drill 3: goal-line jumbo. Number 70 has reported eligible and is the right end; Y is the left end and U a wing outside 70.

Answer 3 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

Takeaways

- **Seven on the line, two eligible ends, everyone else at least a yard off.** These rules date from the 1910 reforms, and their modern job is to let the defense count: at most five eligible receivers against an under-center quarterback, all of them visible by position and number.
- **A covered receiver is ineligible.** When a receiver outside a tight end steps onto the line, the tight end is no longer the end. That is a free clue that he is not going out.
- **The letters follow the rules.** X (split end) is on the line so the formation has its seventh man and its second end; Z (flanker) is off it, so he can go in motion and avoid the jam; Y is the in-line tight end; H and F are the move players. Slot, wing and in-line describe where, whatever the letter.
- **Quarterback depth is a trade.** Under center hides the ball and helps the run and play-action; shotgun buys vision and time; pistol mixes the two. NFL teams in 2025 spread from about 17% to about 59% under center.
- **Splits and strength are clues, not guarantees.** A reduced split opens the outside; strength is a rule each team picks (tight end, receivers, field), and formations that make the rules disagree force the defense to commit.
- **Reporting eligible lets a lineman catch a pass**, after the referee tells the defense. The Patriots’ January 2015 four-lineman trick led to the 2015 rule that keeps players who report ineligible inside the tackle box.

Connections

Builds on: Personnel (who is on the field, including the jumbo group), The Twenty-Two (eligible and ineligible receivers, positions and numbers) and The Pre-Snap Phase (set, shift and motion).

Sets up:

- Classic Formations: the I, the offset I, the pro set and the singleback, built from this chapter’s spots, and the history of under center versus shotgun.
- Spread Formations: 2x2, trips, bunch, empty and the condensed splits introduced here.
- A First Look at Defense: how a defense counts the box and declares its own strength.
- Motion and Shifts: why the off-the-line players move, and what flipping the strength does to a defense.
- RPOs: illegal man downfield, the foul that keeps linemen honest.
- The Lions under Ben Johnson and Dan Campbell: the jumbo package in full.

If you want to go deeper: the NFL rulebook itself (Rule 5 on numbering and reporting, Rule 7 on the formation, Rule 8 on eligibility) is short and readable, and free on NFL Football Operations; Chris B. Brown's *The Art of Smart Football* on formations and strength; and Tim Layden's *Blood, Sweat and Chalk* for the flanker, the shotgun and the other alignment inventions.

Go deeper

From diagrams to real tracking data. Every diagram in this chapter is drawn in NFL Big Data Bowl coordinates, and the animation above is simulated tracking in the same format (simulated, BDB-format). The 2025 Big Data Bowl release labels each play's `offenseFormation` and `receiverAlignment` ("3x1", "2x2" and so on) and records every player's position at the snap, so you can find real versions of these formations and check the rules yourself: count who is within a yard of the line. The data needs a free Kaggle login, so this code is not run when the book is built.

Answers to Predict the play

Answer 1.

Four eligible receivers: X, Z, U and the running back. Count the line: X, five linemen, Y and Z make eight. X is the left end and Z, now on the line, is the right end. **Y is covered**, so he cannot catch a pass. U (a wing, off the line) and the back are eligible from the backfield. The quarterback is under center, so he isn't.

What it suggests: the offense just took its tight end out of the passing game on purpose, which leans toward a **run**, probably to the right, where Y and Z can both block (Z is now close to being a blocker on the edge). It is not a certainty. A team can cover Y on a play-action pass in which Y was only ever going to block. But a defense that sees it can stop worrying about Y in coverage, and a viewer can cross him off the list of targets. If Y does run a route on a pass, look for the flag: illegal man downfield.

Answer 2.

It depends on the rule, and this formation is built to make the rules disagree. By the tight end rule, the strong side is right (the boundary). By receiver count and by the field, it is left.

The most common defensive answer is a split call: the front, the run defenders, set toward the tight end, because that is where the extra blocker is; the coverage leans toward the three receivers and the field, often with a safety rotating that way or a linebacker walking out over the third receiver. Some defenses instead set the front to the field and trust a single linebacker to handle the tight-end side, which leaves the boundary light against the run.

Why the offense likes this: whichever way the defense leans, something is light. If the safety rotates to the trips, a run toward the tight end has fewer defenders to beat; if the defense stays home on the tight-end side, the three receivers have more room. Watch which way this defense goes on the first such snap, and it will probably do the same thing all day.

Answer 3.

Most likely a run, most likely to the right, behind 70. Jumbo exists to add a blocker at the point of attack, and the offense has just put its biggest one at the right edge with a wing outside him. Everything about the picture says "we are going to push you off the goal line": six linemen, two tight ends, a fullback. The defense will usually match with its own heavy goal-line group.

If it is a pass, it is almost certainly play-action, and the surprise targets are the players the defense has stopped worrying about: the tight ends sneaking out after faking a block, the fullback in the flat, and, now and then, 70 himself, who has already been announced to the whole stadium. That is the gamble of the eligible tackle. The announcement gives away that he *can* catch it; the offense is betting that, after watching him block a dozen times, the defense won't believe he *will*.